PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Suzuki Jimny JB23 / JB43

1998–2018 · JB23 · JB33 · JB43 · JB53

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Crawl under it before anything else**
  BigJimny's buying guide calls rust 'the main issue with most Jimnys.' Look at the body and coil-spring mounts on the chassis, the factory welds and the rear crossmember. A body-on-frame truck can look fine from above while the mounts are rotting. One forum owner's 2000 Jimny failed its UK MOT on two body mounts and the rear crossmember.

- [ ] **Pull up the boot floor and the rear seat**
  The rear seat bench lifts out by hand. Check the floor around the rear seat-belt anchors, the tool well above the exhaust and the joint between the rear floor and the inner arches. BigJimny says this is the most common rot-through, and it's worse on soft tops.

- [ ] **Look behind the headlamps and the cladding**
  The cavity behind each headlamp is a water drain that rarely drains properly, and the plastic sill and arch cladding hides rust until it's advanced. Pop the inner arch liners if the seller will let you.

- [ ] **Listen for a clunk pulling away**
  A clunk from the rear in first gear points to loose or worn radius-arm mounts. The mounting holes can wear oval and the brackets can rust through, which needs welding.

- [ ] **Drive it at 45–50 mph**
  Steering shake in that band is the classic Jimny 'death wobble,' usually from worn kingpin bearings. Gear oil weeping onto the swivel balls means the halfshaft seal has gone too. It's fixable, but price it in.

- [ ] **Engage 4WD on a loose surface**
  Try 4WD and low range on gravel and listen for the front hubs clicking in. Erratic engagement on lever cars means vacuum leaks. On push-button cars, flashing 4WD lights usually point to the transfer-case actuator or its wiring.

- [ ] **Abuse the transfer case, briefly**
  BigJimny's test: a hard launch in first. A loud machine-gun rattle with no movement means a stretched transfer chain. Used transfer cases are cheap, so it's a bargaining point rather than a deal-breaker.

- [ ] **Importing? Read the build plate**
  The 25-year exemption runs from the date of manufacture, not the model year, so check the build date before you pay. Get the export certificate and import paperwork, and check how your state titles right-hand-drive kei imports before the truck lands.

YEARS TO KNOW

2004	BEWARE	European JB53 diesel arrives with Renault's 65 PS K9K 700, whose fuel pump failures can ruin the engine
2005	BEWARE	Push-button electric transfer case, new interior and the R72 manual gearbox. BigJimny says early R72s (about 2005–2008) are prone to bearing failure; listen for noise in third

and fourth

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Lateral (panhard) rod bolts may loosen**
  Built 9 May 2012 – 24 March 2014 · UK defect notice (2018)

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Model code and VIN**
  BigJimny's manual guide notes the model is coded in the VIN: JB23 (Japanese kei), JB33 (G13BB Wide), JB43 (M13A Wide/Sierra) and JB53 (diesel). The VIN is in the engine bay below the windscreen, on top of the dash and stamped in the chassis rail behind a rear wheel. The Mazda version is coded JM23.
- [ ] **Kei or Wide**
  A JB23 has no fender flares and small bumpers to stay within Japan's kei-car size limits (3,395 x 1,475 mm). The Wide/Sierra has flares, larger bumpers and is 1,600 mm wide.
- [ ] **Lever or buttons**
  A transfer-case lever between the gearshift and handbrake means a pre-2005 truck. Three dash buttons (2WD, 4WD, 4WD-L) mean the later electric transfer case, used on every M13A VVT Jimny.
- [ ] **Bumper generations**
  BigJimny dates the fronts: first bumper 1998–2005, a deeper second bumper 2006–2012, and a shallower third bumper with a hood scoop and new grille from 2012.
- [ ] **Diesel and 2WD oddities**
  A JB53 diesel has a prominent fake intake bulge on the hood. Rare 2WD-only Jimnys exist, including the export JB33 2WD (1998–2000) and the Japanese Jimny L / J2 (JB23, 2000–2002); no transfer lever on an early-interior truck is the giveaway.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/suzuki/jimny-jb23/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks